

it was the improved Sidewinder that above all gave the Sea Harriers the edge in air combat. For since the mid-1970s, the American heat-seeking missile had become “all-aspect” – that is, it no longer needed to be fired from behind an enemy aircraft to seek out its target.

In many ways the Falklands War was anachronistic. By the 1980s air war had already moved into a new era. In retrospect, the Vietnam War and the Middle East wars of 1967–73 could be seen as a transitional phase, in which missiles, smart bombs, and the ever more complex head-to-head between guidance systems and electronic countermeasures had begun to transform aerial warfare. But it was only with the arrival of a new generation of astonishingly sophisticated and expensive fighters and strike aircraft in the 1970s, backed up by AWACS (airborne warning and control systems), that an unbridgeable gulf would open up between the technologically most adept and the rest.

SEA HARRIER TAKEOFF

A Royal Navy Sea Harrier air-superiority fighter launches from the ramp of HMS Invincible. The Sea Harrier's short takeoff capability enabled the Royal Navy to provide air cover in the Falklands conflict without a full-size aircraft carrier.

